Rejoice in the Lord Always

Christian joy and contentment do not depend on our circumstances but on the Lord, who is near, hears our prayers and gives strength for every situation.

Main passage	Philippians 4:4-13 (KJV)
Topic	Joy
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: Rejoice in the Lord, always	7 min
Teaching point 2: Pray instead of worrying	7 min
Teaching point 3: Learn contentment through Christ's strength	7 min
Discussion questions	7 min
Application	3 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Ask: "Finish this sentence: I would be happy if ..." Let people call out answers (more money, better health, a different job, the children settled). Then reveal where Paul was when he wrote "Rejoice in the Lord always": in prison, chained to a guard, not knowing whether he would live or die.

Scripture (3 min)

Philippians 4:4-13

[4] Rejoice in the Lord alway: and again I say, Rejoice. [5] Let your moderation be known unto all men. The Lord is at hand. [6] Be careful for nothing; but in every thing by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known unto God. [7] And the peace of God, which passeth all understanding, shall keep your hearts and minds through Christ Jesus. [8] Finally, brethren, whatsoever things are true, whatsoever things are honest, whatsoever things are just, whatsoever things are pure, whatsoever things are lovely, whatsoever things are of good report; if there be any virtue, and if there be any praise, think on these

things. [9] Those things, which ye have both learned, and received, and heard, and seen in me, do: and the God of peace shall be with you. [10] But I rejoiced in the Lord greatly, that now at the last your care of me hath flourished again; wherein ye were also careful, but ye lacked opportunity. [11] Not that I speak in respect of want: for I have learned, in whatsoever state I am, therewith to be content. [12] I know both how to be abased, and I know how to abound: every where and in all things I am instructed both to be full and to be hungry, both to abound and to suffer need. [13] I can do all things through Christ which strengtheneth me.

Read the passage aloud. Ask the class to listen for every mention of "the Lord."

Background (5 min)

Paul wrote Philippians while under arrest, probably in Rome (1:13). The church in Philippi was one of his dearest; it had sent him gifts more than once (4:15-16). Even so, the letter is full of joy. "Joy" and "rejoice" appear again and again.

The church was not problem-free: two women, Euodias and Syntyche, were at odds (4:2). Paul's call to joy, gentleness and peace is not a call to ignore problems. It shows the way through them.

Teaching point 1: Rejoice in the Lord, always (7 min)

Paul does not say "rejoice in your circumstances" but "rejoice in the Lord." Circumstances change; the Lord does not. That is why the command can say "alway." Joy is not the same as feeling happy every moment. It is a settled gladness in who God is and what he has done, and it can live alongside tears.

Supporting verses

Philippians 4:4-5: Rejoice in the Lord alway: and again I say, Rejoice. Let your moderation be known unto all men. The Lord is at hand.

Nehemiah 8:10: Then he said unto them, Go your way, eat the fat, and drink the sweet, and send portions unto them for whom nothing is prepared: for this day is holy unto our Lord: neither be ye sorry; for the joy of the LORD is your strength.

Habakkuk 3:17-18: Although the fig tree shall not blossom, neither shall fruit be in the vines; the labour of the olive shall fail, and the fields shall yield no meat; the flock shall be cut off from the fold, and there shall be no herd in the stalls: Yet I will rejoice in the LORD, I will joy in the God of my salvation.

> *"It is the privilege of Christians to do this, not at certain periods and at distant intervals, but at all times they may rejoice that there is a God and Saviour"*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Philippians 4:4

Handout blanks (answers)

Rejoice in the **Lord** alway.

Our joy rests on who God is, not on our **circumstances**.

Teaching point 2: Pray instead of worrying (7 min)

"Be careful for nothing" means "do not be anxious about anything." This is not a command to stop caring. Barnes notes that it does not forbid all care for worldly matters. It is an invitation to turn our worries into prayers, "with thanksgiving." The promise is God's peace guarding our hearts and minds. Verse 8 adds that what we think about matters too.

Supporting verses

Philippians 4:6-9: Be careful for nothing; but in every thing by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known unto God. And the peace of God, which passeth all understanding, shall keep your hearts and minds through Christ Jesus. Finally, brethren, whatsoever things are true, whatsoever things are honest, whatsoever things are just, whatsoever things are pure, whatsoever things are lovely, whatsoever things are of good report; if there be any virtue, and if there be any praise, think on these things. Those things, which ye have both learned, and received, and heard, and seen in me, do: and the God of peace shall be with you.

1 Peter 5:7: Casting all your care upon him; for he careth for you.

Matthew 6:31-34: Therefore take no thought, saying, What shall we eat? or, What shall we drink? or, Wherewithal shall we be clothed? (For after all these things do the Gentiles seek:) for your heavenly Father knoweth that ye have need of all these things. But seek ye first the kingdom of God, and his righteousness; and all these things shall be added unto you. Take therefore no thought for the morrow: for the morrow shall take thought for the things of itself. Sufficient unto the day is the evil thereof.

> *"be not anxious or solicitous about the things of the present life."*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Philippians 4:6

> *"The peace here particularly referred to is that which is felt when we have no anxious care about the supply of our wants"*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Philippians 4:7

Handout blanks (answers)

Be careful for nothing; but in every thing by **prayer** and supplication.

The peace of God shall **keep (guard)** your hearts and minds.

Teaching point 3: Learn contentment through Christ's strength (7 min)

"I have learned … to be content" (v. 11). Contentment does not come naturally; it is learned, often in hard school. Paul learned it in plenty and in hunger. Barnes notes that keeping the heart right in prosperity takes as much grace as in adversity, perhaps more. The secret is verse 13: Christ's strength is enough for every situation he brings us into.

Supporting verses

Philippians 4:11-13: Not that I speak in respect of want: for I have learned, in whatsoever state I am, therewith to be content. I know both how to be abased, and I know how to abound: every where and in all things I am instructed both

to be full and to be hungry, both to abound and to suffer need. I can do all things through Christ which strengtheneth me.

1 Timothy 6:6-8: But godliness with contentment is great gain. For we brought nothing into this world, and it is certain we can carry nothing out. And having food and raiment let us be therewith content.

Hebrews 13:5: Let your conversation be without covetousness; and be content with such things as ye have: for he hath said, I will never leave thee, nor forsake thee.

> *"It requires as much grace to keep the heart right in prosperity as it does in adversity, and perhaps more."*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Philippians 4:12

> *"it was a disposition which he had by grace; and he was enabled to do all by the power of an indwelling Christ."*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Philippians 4:13

Handout blanks (answers)

I have **learned**, in whatsoever state I am, therewith to be content.

I can do all things through **Christ** which strengtheneth me.

Teacher note: Verse 13 is often quoted as a promise of success in anything we attempt. In context it means strength to be content and faithful in every circumstance, whether in want or in plenty.

Discussion questions (7 min)

1. How is "rejoicing in the Lord" different from simply being happy?

Happiness depends on what happens; joy in the Lord rests on God's unchanging character and promises, and can coexist with sorrow.

2. What is the difference between caring about something and being anxious about it?

Care takes responsible action; anxiety carries the weight as if everything depends on us. Prayer hands the weight to God.

3. Why do you think Paul says contentment is "learned"?

It grows through experience of God's faithfulness in both good and hard times; it is a discipline, not a personality type.

4. Why might prosperity test our hearts as much as hardship does?

Plenty can make us proud, self-reliant and forgetful of God; want tends to drive us to him.

Application (3 min)

Each time you notice yourself worrying this week, stop and turn it into a short prayer, ending with one thing you are thankful for. Write down any worries you prayed about, and at the end of the week, note how God gave you peace.

Closing prayer (2 min)

Lord, you are near. Teach us to rejoice in you always, not only when life is easy. We bring you our worries and give them to you with thanks. Let your peace guard our hearts and minds in Christ Jesus. Teach us contentment, in plenty and in want, and strengthen us for whatever this week brings. In Jesus' name, Amen.

Sources quoted

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Philippians 4:4

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Philippians 4:6

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Philippians 4:7

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on Philippians 4:12

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Philippians 4:13

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